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1 reader reports

1.1 key issues

Below are my responses to the three key issues outlined in your email.

1.1.1 How does the argument accumulate over the chapters?

Language technologies reduce language complexity to make it computable. Words are removed from their original context, cleaned and standardized, so that they can be stored and analyzed at scale. These increasingly automated processes encode dominant logics and extractive incentives onto language data, creating well-documented issues with data sovereignty, privacy, and most recently, bias, as current AI tools demonstrate.

This book breaks open and re-works technologies for analyzing language about sex, gender and sexuality. It takes a close look into technologies like web scraping, text analysis, machine learning, among others. Then, drawing from concepts in Queer Studies and related fields, it re-works these technologies into new analytical methodologies that open up, rather than reduce, novel readings of language data.

Each of the five chapters considers a different technology for working with language. For that technology, the chapter identifies a technical constraint that reduces or flattens language meaning. For example, chapter 2, "Text Analysis," explores the technology of quantitative text analysis, and within that technology, the constraint of iteration: a logic of repetition in which text analysis programs execute the same action across large collections of text, one word at a time. This constraint, which allows quantitative text analysis to clean and regularize texts en masse, suppresses minor details in language forms in favor of the most frequent textual patterns. The chapter then takes

Judith Butler's concept of Gender Performativity, which describes gender as a social and behavioral phenomenon that becomes intelligible through habit or repetition, to re-work computational iteration into a new text analysis practice for studying subtle gender markers and descriptions in language. Unlike typical text analysis projects, which prioritize dominant semantic patterns and relationships, this new methodology uses quantification to surface the idiosyncracies and nuances in language meaning.

The rest of the chapters similarly re-work computational processes and their constraints by applying a conceptual tool from Queer Studies. The table below sketches these dynamics.

Chapter	Technology	Technical Constraint	Conceptual Tool
1. Text Capture	Web Scraping	Protocol	Reparative Reading
2. Text Analysis	Quantitative Text Analysis	Iteration	Gender Performativity (Butler)
3. Text Preservation	Markup Language	Containment	Dis-Identification (Muñoz)
4. Text Display	Screen Display	Abstraction	Fleshiness (Musser)
5. Text Generation	Machine Learning	Aggregation	Body Dysphoria (Prosser)

Each chapter tests its methodology on a different literary object. The earlier chapters explore traditional works of queer literature (Gloria Anzaldúa's *Borderlands/La Frontera: The New Mestiza*, 1987; Virginia Woolf's *Orlando: A Biography*, 1928; Oscar Wilde's *The Picture of Dorian Gray*, 1890), and the latter chapters take on more eclectic source material, some of which features heterosexual characters, from science fiction, electronic literature and reality TV (Octavia Butler's *Dawn*, 1987; Entropy8Zuper!'s *skinonskinon-skin*, 1999; *Love is Blind*, 2020+). While the early chapters showcase novel readings of canonical works, the expansion of source material in the latter chapters poses new orientations around queerness based on embodiment and shared experience. Echoing Butler's famous call for queerness which is "never fully owned, but always and only redeployed, twisted, queered from a prior usage and in the direction of urgent and expanding political purposes" this book illustrates how digital tools and methods, rather than offering solutions for understanding queerness or making it legible, creates opportunities for exploring its ever shifting permutations. (173).

Re-defining "queer" for the future involves not just expanding subject matter, but also developing a robust conceptual toolset for doing resistance work. As the earlier chapters show, Queer Studies' initial (and necessary) emphasis on identity politics offers resistance methods that operate from *within* systems of power. The first three chapters thus explore ways for

re-working protocols and structures in order to deconstruct and reassemble totalizing logics. However, the latter chapters, which draw from more recent Trans- and Black Feminist-inflected work in Queer Studies, foreground methodologies that work *alongside* and *beyond* these systems. These methodologies center material realities and embodied experiences in ways that are not (and that cannot be) contained within existing systems. The book ultimately argues that both approaches, working inside and working beyond—shifting between opposition and collaboration, from co-opting to co-creating—are necessary for resistance.

This book's focus on transforming theory into conceptual tools for doing DH analysis (explained in more detail in the Methodology question) sets it apart from other works in the Queer DH field, which explicitly emphasize queer subjects and/or objects of analysis.

1.1.2 What is the urgency?

Language technologies are increasingly black-boxed and automated. This book offers a blueprint for how language technologies work from the inside. It examines a "stack" of language technologies that progress from preliminary to advanced, from gathering language data, to cleaning and processing it, to visualizing and displaying it. The book begins with three chapters on the preliminary processes of gathering and structuring text, as well as exploratory analysis ("Text Capture," "Text Analysis," "Text Preservation"). These chapters introduce foundational concepts of text quantification and textual markup (i.e., of counting word frequencies and structuring text data), which the later chapters develop into more advanced and layered processes of screen display and generative AI ("Text Display," "Text Generation").

This scaffolded approach progressively builds a knowledge base over the course of the book. Through exposure to the logics of computational procedures, readers from various disciplinary background learn technical strategies to re-work the all but inevitable language technologies that proliferate around them.

1.1.3 What is the methodological intervention?

In response to the reviewer's comment about the close reading methodology working against the book's larger goal of introducing to digital tools: I actually see the two of them working in tandem.

Close reading is the means for introducing digital tools, making them legible in a Literary Studies register. The book applies close reading to examine

the inner workings of digital processes, to excavate how these processes work on the level of technological mechanism. It then seeks analogues for their mechanisms from the field of Queer Studies, which is rich with strategies for destabilizing, resisting and co-opting authoritative and delimiting structures. It applies these strategies from Queer Studies as conceptual *tools* for technical experimentation—using them to re-work constraining mechanisms into new methodologies that open up novel readings of language data.

I am inspired by Matthew Kirschenbaum's approach in his book, *Mechanisms: New Media And The Forensic Imagination*. In that book, Kirschenbaum offers deep readings of computer hardware, like the hard drive and the floppy disk, to the level of nanoscale. I studied with Kirschenbaum during my MA at U of Maryland, and he advised me on the first digital project that I ever created. I see my own methodology as expanding his literary approach for close reading digital phenomena into the realm of Queer Studies.

1.2 feedback

- overall issues, how the project is currently constituted
 - how does **argument accumulate** in each chapter?
 - * connection between object and theory ought to feel necessary
 - * stronger grounding in book's overall argument
 - * "what the bringing together of queer studies/theory with digital humanities tools and technologies does to transform or critique the field"
 - "what takeaway does this give us that is broadly applicable within that field? What does it reveal about either the technology discussed or queer theory broadly?"
 - where is the **urgency**?
 - * feels like series of term papers
 - * needs strong contribution to the discipline
 - what is the **methodological** intervention?
 - * case needs to be made for the innovativeness of methodology, as it appears to be mostly close reading for now
 - how does close reading work wrt digital tools?
 - "its reliance on close reading seems to work against its goal of working as an introduction to digital tools"
 - * consider *Data Feminism* as a model

- length can be expanded

I agree that the length can be expanded. Since I've been further revising my chapters over this spring, I have a more precise sense of how the argument in the larger argument coheres. I plan to expand all the chapters to include sections that explicitly integrate the book's larger argument and methodological intervention.

- citing prior Dh work

My introduction draws heavily from the scholars mentioned by the reviewer, especially Jason Boyd and Bo Ruberg. As the reviewer points out, these scholars helped to form the Queer DH field back in 2016-18. The introduction also draws from Kara Keeling, Jacob Gaboury, TL Cowan, and Jas Rault who all work in the intersection of queerness and computation, and from queer digital historiographical work by Cait McKinney and Avery Dame-Griff.

Below is a list of works most influential for this project, including some more recent sources, as the reviewer suggests.

Barnett, Fiona, Zach Blas, micha cárdenas, Jacob Gaboury, Jessica Marie Johnson, and Margaret Rhee. "QueerOS: A User's Manual." *Debates in the Digital Humanities* 2016. 2016.

Boyd, Jason and Bo Ruberg. "Queer Digital Humanities." *The Bloomsbury Handbook to the Digital Humanities*. 2022.

Cowan, T. L., and Jas Rault. *Heavy Processing*. Punctum books, 2024.

Dame-Griff, Avery. *The Two Revolutions: A History Of The Transgender Internet*. Vol. 1. NYU Press, 2023.

McKinney, Cait. *Information Activism: A Queer History Of Lesbian Media Technologies*. University of Texas Press. 2022.

Keeling, Kara. "Queer Os." *Cinema Journal* 53.2 (2014): 152-157. 2014.

Ruberg, Bo, Jason Boyd, and James Howe. "Toward A Queer Digital Humanities." *Bodies of information: Intersectional Feminism And The Digital Humanities* (2018): 108-128.

Ruberg, Bo. *Video Games Have Always Been Queer*. New York University Press, 2019.

I am not familiar with the essay, "Encoding/ Decoding" by Stuart Hall, but I am grateful for the reviewer's recommendation for a firmer grounding in Cultural Studies.

- title change

I agree that the title, in particular the phrasing "Counter Code," could be stronger. Here are a couple of alternatives for the main title, based on "Queer Code" and "Queer Computation," as opposed to "Counter Code."

Queer Code: Re-Working Language Technologies

Queer Code: Re-Visioning Language Technologies

Queer Computation: Re-Coding Language Technologies

- writing style

I agree that the writing should be as lucid and accessible as possible. One of the project's main goals is to speak across disciplinary audiences, and especially to introduce digital tools and knowledge to scholars from humanities backgrounds who consider themselves non-technical.

2 Bibliography

Anzaldúa, Gloria. *Borderlands/La Frontera: The New Mestiza*. Aunt Lute Books. 1987.

Butler, Judith. *Bodies That Matter: On the Discursive Limits of "Sex"*. Routledge, 2011.

Kirschenbaum, Matthew G. *Mechanisms: New Media And The Forensic Imagination*. MIT Press. 2012.

Muñoz, José Esteban. *Disidentifications: Queers of Color and the Performance of Politics*. José Esteban Muñoz. University of Minnesota Press, 1999.

Musser, Amber Jamilla. *Sensual Excess: Queer Femininity and Brown Jouissance*. NYU Press, 2018.

Prosser, Jay. *Second Skins: The Body Narratives of Transsexuality*. Columbia University Press. 1998.